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Virginia Board of Education, Special Committee on Standards of Accreditation, Wednesday, October 14, 2020

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- Official meeting video (VDOE, YouTube): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=5w1i2Pfq7ms
- Board of Education meetings, agendas and minutes (VDOE): https://www.doe.virginia.gov/state-board-data-funding/virginia-board-of-education

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Speech-to-text: whisper.cpp, model large-v3-turbo. Produced 2026-10-24. Each paragraph starts with its time [HH:MM:SS] in the meeting video.

[00:00:31] - Seems to be working now, Shelley, maybe. - Just had to unplug it and replug it for some reason. - Yeah, that's always my go-to. - Reboot is always the go-to, yeah.

[00:00:41] - Yeah.

[00:02:57] - Everything appears to be working correctly. So I passed it on to you. - I was muted. Thanks, Kevin.

[00:03:18] Good afternoon for everybody joining us. I wanted to let you know that we are live streaming. Our connection is complete on our YouTube page. We're just waiting for more of our DOE staff board members and panelists to join us um and we will get started here right at two o'clock

[00:03:37] hi there everybody joining us uh wanted to let you all know that we are live streaming on youtube

[00:06:29] we're waiting for folks to join uh we have more board members and staff and panelists that are going to be joining us so we will get started here in just a couple of minutes can you hear me yes i can leslie okay and can i ask you a technical question do we have it just set up that you only see the the slideshow as opposed to the presenters I might just

[00:07:08] have to figure out so when it's when it's record or when it's live they'll see the slideshow but they'll also see the presenter in the top right corner I believe okay I just didn't have the screen where you could see me so I was make sure that i wasn't oddly positioned yeah i have it to where all my videos can be seen on the side okay um i'm not sure if that's default or not okay i'll just keep clicking around thank you

[00:07:44] and i'll take down screen share as soon as we get started but i wanted folks that are joining us on the live stream to know we're going to start here in just a couple of minutes okay and emily this is bliss parker can you see me and hear me just want to double check i can definitely hear you let me look right now you are a black screen um you can definitely hear you okay good to know i'll

[00:08:21] work on that thank you okay and actually i'm gonna go ahead and stop screen share that way folks can maybe actually see each other still waiting on a couple more folks to join us and then we'll go

[00:08:56] ahead and get started how are we doing emily i'm counting right now to see where we are

[00:10:07] i think uh we're still waiting on dr duran so we'll give folks it's just now two we'll give folks another minute or two to hop on okay good afternoon everyone good afternoon i keep showing um unstable internet so i'll keep my video off thanks for letting us know yeah that happens to

[00:10:42] me sometimes and usually taking video down helps a little bit. All right, we have Dr. Duran, we have Mrs. Davis-Faught, Dr. Wilson, Dr. Pexton is here, we have President Gecker, Dr. Mann, my internet connection is now unstable, so I'll take my video down. We have Ms. Holton that's joined us and we have i'm trying to see if we have all of our panelists too one two three

[00:11:19] four five six we have all of our panelists here and all of our daf uh who is presenting first so um with that uh dr wilson i think we are ready to go thank you emily and good afternoon to everyone I am not Dr. Keisha Pexton, who chairs this committee.

[00:11:46] Dr. Pexton is actually a bit under the weather, and so we do hope she is on the line and will be participating as she can, but she's asked me to facilitate today's meeting. And so I welcome all of you. Thank you for taking time this afternoon to share with us, if you're on the panel or the DOE staff, as well as all who are attending and watching us on the live stream.

[00:12:09] Just to make sure we take care of all of our details, I would like to reiterate the roll call that Emily just did, but I'll do it formally. So if you could let us know that you are present members of the committee, Dr. Keisha Pexton.

[00:12:28] - Present. - Okay, Ms. Pamela Davis Vaught. - Present. - Dr. Francisco Duran. - Present. - And I note other board members are also present. President Gecker is on the line. - Yep, I'm here. as well as Ms. Anne Holton.

[00:12:47] - Yes, looking forward. - Thank you. And Dr. Mann is also on the line. - Yes, also having problems with the internet. - That's okay. Thank you all very much for being here. I will start today's meeting with a number of preliminary comments.

[00:13:04] Our committee met about a month ago to receive a presentation from the Virginia Department of Education staff comparing the federal accountability system with Virginia's accreditation system. Additionally, we were joined last month by a wonderful group of superintendents and school principals who shared their view of the positive, negative and unintended consequences of the 2017 standards of accreditation revisions.

[00:13:31] We were very pleased that they could join us for that thoughtful conversation and so appreciative of their insights. VDOE staff have been meeting for many months as part of an internal work group the implementation of the standards of accreditation and so for today's meeting we will hear from staff on some of the unintended consequences and possible solutions that this doe internal work group have identified additionally we have another stakeholder panel discussion with representatives from the virginia education association the virginia school boards association the virginia pta

[00:14:09] virginia ascd and the virginia school counselors counselors association and the co-chair of the accreditation task force i will note that the committee may invite additional stakeholders to our november meeting to ensure that we receive a diverse set of views and feedback and certainly for our committee members and other board members if there are additional items that we believe would be useful to hear we certainly invite you to share that information with staff as

[00:14:41] well as with dr pexton as the planning continues before we move into this afternoon's presentations have committee members had an opportunity to review the minutes from september 16th if you have do you note any changes or revisions that need to be made to those minutes no changes dr Wilson. Thank you, Dr. Duran. No changes for me. Thank you. So I will entertain a motion then,

[00:15:18] please, to accept the minutes or to approve the minutes from September 16, 2020. So moved to adopt the minutes. Thank you, Dr. Duran. Thank you, Ms. Davis-Vaught. And so all in favor, we must do this by roll call. Dr. Pexton? Aye. Ms. Davis-Vaught? Aye. Dr. Duran? Aye.

[00:15:40] and jamel wilson votes aye so with that that brings us then to the matter of the day uh doe staff presentation on certain unintended consequences related to the 2017 standards of accreditation we are joined this afternoon by shelley loving rider assistant superintendent for student assessment accountability and esa programs julie malik director of accountability and dr leslie sale director of policy if possible we ask that committee members hold your questions until the end of the presentation and we will take them all at the same time and so with that

[00:16:16] i will turn things over then to um miss loving rider who will get us started thank you dr wilson uh leslie sale is actually going to start us off on our press thank you very good dr sale thanks jelly um and thank you dr wilson for for queuing us up um and i just want to quickly get a thumbs up from julie that she is at the helm of our powerpoint slide so i will i will indicate to her one okay perfect um thanks everyone um so again thank you dr wilson for for queuing all

[00:16:53] of this up um and for those of you who i haven't gotten to meet on the call um as dr wilson mentioned my name is leslie sale and i am the director of the office of policy with the virginia department of education and i would just like to quickly thank the committee for for giving us a few minutes of their agenda time this afternoon to to talk through um our presentation and a review of of potential solutions to the select concerns related to the 2017 SOA.

[00:17:20] And Julie, if you wanna go ahead and toggle to the next slide, excuse me. That'll give you something to read as I chat a little bit. So as Dr. Wilson mentioned last month, the committee had the opportunity to hear from a group of panelists, including division superintendents and principals that reflected on how the 2017 revision to the SOA has translated to local practice, changes in practice, and then, of course, outcomes.

[00:17:52] And so as a complement to that presentation, our BDOE staff team, an internal committee, had also provided a written report to the committee that discussed some of the items and issue areas that we had identified as an internal group that also addressed positive, negative, and unintended consequences, particularly those unintended consequences that the panelists spent a lot of time discussing.

[00:18:21] So again, that was a bit of a contextual document for last month's conversation. But we're excited this month to dig in a little bit more and kind of walk you through, first, the nature of our internal work group and the work that we've embarked on since the 2017 revisions, to really dig into some of those specific unintended consequences that we identified in the written report and give you a little bit more information and background and then always thinking forward what will be our next steps as an internal work group so julia if we'll go to the next slide so i have been using the the term internal work group

[00:19:00] but our formal name is the standards of accreditation implementation committee and we really came together as a group and i will say we i'm taking a little bit of ownership since this predated my term with video but um the group did come together as a immediate and direct result of the revisions that happened in 2017 to the standards of accreditation and because of the scale and scope of the revisions that happened in 2017 i think there was a clear recognition that there was going to be a need for technical support and assistance for our local school divisions and and folks that are really on the ground implementing

[00:19:38] these changes so the the primary task and charge of the committee was really to think through just that to start to field the questions and concerns that we were receiving from the field and provide what support and assistance that we could this really was from its outset a across department and cross office collaborative work we've had folks who were representing pretty much every every department and office across the agency that that have kind of a substantive programmatic investment in the standards of accreditation i guess you might say including policy research

[00:20:15] instruction assessment student services school quality and data management so we really have kind of a broad swath of our video team represented on the stakeholder committee um as we received feedback from our local school divisions and those folks that were intimately involved in implementing the standards of accreditation in 2017 we were able to troubleshoot a good number of issue areas and questions that arose through existing pathways so we provided some new guidance we offered clarifications through superintendents correspondence like

[00:20:50] superintendents emails and memos we provided webinars and training opportunities for local school divisions and then when there was a demonstrated need or an occasion that required board action. We did pursue those as well if necessary. Julie, I'll have you go to the next slide. Thank you. So again, as much of our work so far has been kind of in a reactive space, I would say, we've been responding to a lot of input and feedback that we've been collecting from the field and from our local stakeholders. But really in this past year has been kind of a

[00:21:28] substantive shift and pivot for us to think a little bit more proactively. And I guess I will say that we are kind of embracing this concept of continuous improvement that we find in the SOA and thinking about some additional opportunities for growth and really reflecting on the information that we've gotten back from the field to target some issue areas and concepts and questions that we think would be a value add and a contribution to making the SOA as effective as it can be as a kind of guiding document for the field.

[00:22:03] Next slide, Julie. So with that being said, to kind of set the stage for you, I'm gonna hand it over to Shelly and Julie to really walk through some of the specific recommendations or I guess rather issue areas that we've identified as a group.

[00:22:19] We really are kind of narrowed in on two particular parts that we've discussed in previous presentations. So this presentation will particularly emphasize some items that you find in part three, our student achievement expectations and our graduation requirements as well as accreditation which i know the the board and special committee has has really done a deep dive into as well um just as a preface to our conversation um the the presentation that we have today is not necessarily meant to be comprehensive but really kind of a select curated um walkthrough of the items that we think are really important for the board to have an opportunity to look at

[00:22:57] and discuss and just kind of exemplary of the types of issues that we've seen being raised both from the field and from our internal work group and then i should note as well that we have identified a number of technical edits that will also need to be addressed but aren't included in this presentation um since we wanted this to kind of be more of the substantive substantive items that we've identified over the course of our internal review so i will hand this over to shelly and julie to get the conversation started on the individual items and i will circle back with you guys at the end of the presentation thank you so much leslie as leslie noted um we are going

[00:23:34] to be focusing on part three and part eight today and as leslie also noted uh this is certainly not a comprehensive review but instead just examples of some issues we have identified over the past 18 months or so and some suggestions about how they might be addressed i'm going to do part three and then Julie will do some issues in Part 8. So just as a reminder, Part 3 is the section of the SOA that really sets out the testing requirements, the graduation requirements, and it also provides

[00:24:10] information about expectations for transfer students. So the first section we're going to look at, and Julie you can go to the next slide, is in the assessment requirements for end-of-course tests and this was noted in the document you had last month so the way the language in the SOA currently reads in the section regarding end of course test it requires students if they're sitting in a class that has an end of course test to take that test unless they have already earned

[00:24:43] the verified credits needed for graduation in that subject area or if they need the test for for federal accountability. So the requirement that students take an end of course test, if they're sitting in a class that has one, coupled with the requirement that they take a test for federal accountability does result in students sometimes having to take more than one test in a content area. An example is we could have a ninth grade student who is taking Earth

[00:25:18] science earth science has an end of course test so the way the language is written currently that student must take the earth science end of course test even though that student will be required to take the biology test as a 10th grader to meet federal accountability requirements the way the language is currently written also restricts students flexibility in which world history which history test they might take for verified credit. For example, if they're sitting in World History I, they would have to take that test even though they might prefer to earn their

[00:25:56] verified credit in Virginia and U.S. history. So that's just a statement of the issue. And Julie, if we can go to the next slide, we'll look at the language. And so this is the language in the 2017 SOA we did add the red text for emphasis and many of you will remember under the previous SOA students were

required to take end of course tests if they were sitting in the class even if they did not need them for verified credit. In the 2017 revision the board was very clear in its

[00:26:32] desire to reduce the amount of testing and so your desire was to change the SOA so that students would only be required to take tests if they needed them for verified credits, to reduce the number of verified credits, or if they needed the test for federal accountability. The difficulty we encountered is that the way this was addressed is the second red language. Students shall not be required to take an end-of-course test on an academic subject after they have earned the

[00:27:07] number of verified credits unless that test is needed for federal accountability requirements so what has happened is that first statement each student in middle and secondary schools shall take all applicable and of course sol test because of the shall in that statement it requires students to take a test if there isn't a course test attached to a course unless they have earned the verified credit. Next slide, Julie. So what we would like to recommend is a

[00:27:43] modification to this language to clarify that students would need to take the test needed for federal accountability, reading biology, and an end-of-course math test as appropriate, and that they would only take other end-of-course tests if they're needed for verified credit requirements for graduation. For those of you who've been on the board for a while, you will remember that it is actually this issue um that a year ago when we were discussing how to address this that really precipitated um your movement to open up the soa and to address unintended consequences um so we

[00:28:23] are hopeful that in opening up the soa that we can address this issue so that students will have more flexibility in in which tests they take and will also in the area of science for example not be required to take two end of course tests so that was our first issue and now we'll move on to our second issue so the second issue is in the part section of part three that deals with transfer students and as it is currently it implies that students who transfer into the

[00:29:02] Virginia public schools must take the Algebra 1 SOL test to meet federal accountability requirements. And this is actually not to the intent of the federal law. What the requirement is, is that students who are transferring into the Virginia public schools will need to take the Algebra 1 test only if they are enrolled in Algebra 1.

[00:29:32] otherwise we would not require them to to take the test so uh this we actually attempted to fix this in the the guidance document and you'll note that here it's clarified that we would only require students to take the algebra one test if they're actually enrolled in that class in fact students who transfer in after uh the ninth grade year are not counted for federal accountability um in mathematics so again we attempted this to address this in guidance but we do need to address it

[00:30:08] within the soa next slide julie the third issue deals with the option that school divisions have to verify credits in writing through a local performance assessment you all will remember that this was an option provided to school divisions in the 2017 revision so that school divisions can choose to either administer the SOL into course test for students to earn verified

[00:30:41] credits or they can administer a local performance assessment in writing. In some places in the SOA it refers to this requirement as a performance assessment and in fact it is actually multiple performance assessments that would be used to verify the the writing the the writing verified credit um

and so what we need to do is to clarify the language to to specify that it really is multiple writing samples the guidance that you all have uh approved requires three writing samples

[00:31:18] uh not just one so this is a fairly minor edit just to to go in and clarify that uh in fact it is multiple performance assessments not just just a single performance assessment and we also have an issue with the language that deals with foreign exchange students foreign exchange students are of course students from other countries who come to the united states to spend a semester or a year in a virginia public school and as the soa is currently written it does require students who

[00:31:57] are identified as foreign exchange students to participate in the SOL testing program. This needs to be addressed. These students are not pursuing a Virginia diploma, and so there is no need for them to participate in the testing program. Again, this is another situation where we attempted to address the concern through guidance, but it does need to be

[00:32:26] revised within the soa julie we can go on and now we are uh back to graduation requirements so um this section of the soa uh provides uh information about graduation requirements for students and it clarifies that students who transfer in later in their high school career are required to accrue fewer verified credits and of course this makes sense students who

[00:33:02] transfer in as 10th, 11th, or 12th graders have pursued much of their high school education in a different system. So it would make sense that the number of verified credits would be fewer for students who graduate, who transfer into the Virginia schools later in their high school careers.

[00:33:23] Currently, for students who are transferring in in the 10th grade or the beginning of the 11th grade must earn the same number of verified credits as students who've been with us since the ninth grade. And the concern is that this may be an unreasonable expectation for these students.

[00:33:43] Under the previous SOA, when students were taking tests, if they were in a class that had an end of course test, there was more opportunity for students who transferred in late to accrue a verified credit now that there are fewer fewer requirements to test we do think there may be some difficulty in students earning five verified credits when they transfer in in the 10th or the 11th grade so our recommendation here is uh for us to revisit uh the the required verified credits

[00:34:20] for students who transfer in in their 10th or the 11th grade year julie i think i will turn it to you now to talk about part eight. All right thank you Shelly. So now that we've identified areas in need of consideration in part three there are a few items in note within part eight that we'd like to bring to your attention. I think you've seen that some of these items are maybe slightly more

[00:34:53] technical in nature and some are definitely more involved so you will find that true in part eight as well. The first of these items is the inclusion of writing in the English combined rate. As a quick review, the English combined rate includes results from both the reading and writing SOL assessments, as well as the growth in reading and EL progress where it's appropriate.

[00:35:21] As Shelly mentioned just a few minutes ago, students can now receive their required verified credits in writing by successfully completing multiple performance assessments in high school, locally developed performance assessments in high school with the available use of the writing performance assessments not all schools continue to administer the writing sol assessments therefore schools who do not administer the writing sol have expressed concern that their writing component of the english combined rate is not being that the writing component is not being included for their

[00:35:55] school so the possible solution of course would be to reevaluate the inclusion of writing into the combined rate. This is a drastic change that would require quite a bit of data analysis and it may have a larger impact to the system as a whole. So there would definitely need to be additional investigation to ensure no additional unintended consequences due to that action.

[00:36:23] The next item is fairly simple. In the previous SOA, there was a new school rating for schools who do not yet have data. So for example, if the school opened their doors for the first time in the fall of 2019 as an example. That school still needs a rating for the 19-20 accreditation year, but they don't have any data yet, so the school would have a new school rating for accreditation.

[00:36:49] Since the SOA clearly defines all the applicable accreditation ratings, this would simply involve adding this rating officially back into the SOA to align with current practice. This item is one that the committee has heard a little about over the past few months, particularly last month there has been much concern from some divisions about how late arriving students are being counted in the current dropout rate this discussion has primarily been focused on english learners enrolling as an older high school student the solution is determined if

[00:37:25] flexibilities could be made available in the dropout rate calculation for these students depending on supports being provided to these students as we discuss this item it's very important to note that in the 2020 legislative session, Senate Bill 933 was passed. This bill, although perhaps not completely aligned to all the concerns, charges the DOE with tasks pertaining to SLEIF and SIFE students. If you don't know what SLEIF and SIFE students are, they're students with interrupted or limited formal education. These tasks involve developing a definition,

[00:38:04] identifying supports being provided to those students and then finally if and how these students impact accreditation ratings just to let you know that is there and the BDOE is moving forward on the completion of those tasks and then the last item we're going to bring forth to you all today we're going to talk about touches on something we discussed at the first committee meeting if you recall in our review of the indicators in the current accreditation system a school can move up a level in any indicator if they demonstrate a defined improvement in a

[00:38:38] a defined measure from a previous year. For example, if a school had a chronic absenteeism rate of 16%, which is a level two. But if this rate reflects a reduction from the previous year of 10%, the school would actually receive a level one. So in 22-23, the college career and civics readiness indicator will be included in accreditation for the first time. But when When the revision took place in 2017, data was not readily available to confidently make a determination on a defined improvement value for this indicator.

[00:39:16] We feel that to align with all the other indicators, data analysis should take place to determine if there is an appropriate improvement measure for this indicator. All right. Thank you for your time. Appreciate your attention. I'm going to pass it back over to Dr. Sayle to outline the next steps.

[00:39:34] Julia I'll actually go ahead and hop into the next slide. So as the board special committee continues to do its work, the SOA implementation committee is also going to do its due diligence to make sure that we are exhausting all of our opportunities to have comprehensive and holistic feedback and input both from us internally at the agency but as well as from stakeholders in the field.

[00:40:06] So we are kind of shifting from a place where we have been looking inward to reaching out to respective stakeholders to get some targeted feedback around these individual issue areas that we've

already identified, and then also have them reflect on the new SOA implementation more generally.

[00:40:26] And so that will be done in a fairly curated, targeted way. We're going to reach out to our, and have really already started the process of working with our educational stakeholders, some of which are joining us today as well, including the Virginia Association of Elementary School Principals, Secondary School Principals, and some of the larger organizations, as well as those groups that have a really targeted content knowledge and expertise in certain big areas of the standards of accreditation.

[00:41:00] So that includes special education, career and technical education, among other groups. So we're being very thoughtful and very inclusive in who we bring to the table to make sure that we're capturing input and feedback from all the right stakeholders.

[00:41:15] And of course, we will continue to work collaboratively with the special committee with the board to make sure that we're providing the support you all need to be well informed in your decisions moving forward. And I will say, hopefully, without providing too much of a spoiler for tomorrow's board meeting, we will actually be bringing the Notice of Intended Regulatory Action for the regulations establishing the standards of accreditation so that we can begin the formal regulatory process, which we hope will include and incorporate feedback that we've gathered from both the internal process as well as the board's process.

[00:41:52] So that will be a formal next step that we will take tomorrow. So with that being said, I think we're ready to close out the presentation, but hand it back over to the committee for any questions or anything that we can provide additionally in terms of information or context.

[00:42:11] Thank you, Shelley, Leslie, Julie, appreciate the presentation and the information. I'll ask here if any committee members have questions or comments that they would like to verbalize. Dr. Wilson.

[00:42:29] Dr. Duran. Yes. Thank you everyone for the overview, the comprehensive overview, not only just what the issues were, what some possible solutions were. It's good to see that a lot of work has been done, I can tell, on everyone's part in really trying to manage and understand the complexities and adhering to the federal requirements. So thank you for that. I would like just to have a little bit more information on the SLIFE and SIFE work that's being done and the possible solution and and what that might look like and I think you shared that some work has already begun and you

[00:43:05] know we're starting to unpack that it maybe was the word I'm not sure the word used but please share with us a little bit more about what that means and what that possible solution might look like what your framework of thinking is at this time thank you Dr. Duran we're just at the very beginning stages now we're really trying to work on identifying how would we define slife and scythe in such a way that we collect that information that really is the first step in then working with school divisions to determine what kind of supports are being provided to students

[00:43:41] and really it will be at that point that we can think more closely about any kind of flexibility that might be provided within the accreditation system so we're really at the very beginning stages now okay thank you for that and i appreciate that you are at the beginning stage and it's on the table for discussion and i look forward to as you develop that to bring back what some of the thinking is and what some of the work has been done and the pros and cons because i know there are some challenges with this and i i for one definitely want to make sure that we are holding high standards for our stipend size students and we're making sure that they have all opportunities

[00:44:19] afforded to them and that we're not creating a way that they are not going to what i appreciate about it is making sure that people are paying attention to who those students are and they're not being lost to the crack which they have been in the past at the same time we've heard and seen that there could be some unintended consequences with that good intention to make sure that we're paying attention to that student group so i know that's not an easy ask of you and i appreciate your answer it's letting writer that you're just in the beginning of that because that's a complex one but i want to very much thank you for having it as an issue that you're talking about and we'll

[00:44:52] be bringing back thank you dr wilson thank you other questions from committee members i had a couple of questions um one had to do with uh foreign exchange students and them uh their testing being incorporated right how how are foreign exchange students counted in um daily membership or um yeah how do we count them with our attendance dr ball said i i do not know

[00:45:30] there may be someone else from DOE who knows but but I do not well I guess my only observation so we don't have to dig too far but my observation is depending on how those students are counted in attendance the extent to which that mirrors or mimics the way other students are counted in attendance when it comes to testing we'll of course want to make sure that we unravel that you know what I mean and not um create some on another unintended consequence if there is such so thank you for just noting that and then the other question I had was um the number do we have

[00:46:07] any idea the number of divisions right now that are you actively using performance assessments uh for writing for the writing score um we are currently in the process of collecting that information for this year now of course because we are in the the covid situation we are not certain that we will have as many school divisions participating in that as they might have we can certainly get you that information for last year but we don't have it for this year yet okay it would be i would be interested in just knowing what last year's number was

[00:46:45] sure that would be great any other questions from committee members or other board members who are on the call not seeing or hearing any so let me just thank you all again for the presentation for providing the information and as dr duran pointed out also coming forward with some recommended the path forward what we might be what you might do to help address a number of the issues i'm particularly heartened to see your intent to involve stakeholders directly in this work so

[00:47:20] that as we unravel what we've identified as unintended consequences we we know that we are staying aligned to what we're hearing in the field so thank you for that i'll also thank you leslie for acknowledging that the nora is on the agenda for tomorrow's board meeting for those who are interested i believe it is in the consent agenda as it is a notice it is not any other formal action and so it is noted there under the consent agenda so those are my only comments and so with

[00:47:51] that will close out this part of the meeting and with thanks again to you all welcome so now we will pivot to our panel discussion with a number of stakeholder associations who've agreed to gather and talk a bit about again positive negative and unintended consequences of the 2017 revisions to the standards of accreditation i'm going to moderate the panel with a number of questions and hoping to provide you all the opportunity to share your insights. It's nice to see familiar

[00:48:28] faces and smiles of folks that I haven't seen in quite some time. So thank you all so much for taking time to be with us this afternoon. Let me please introduce our panelists. We have Ms. Jenna Alexander, who serves as the Vice President for Advocacy for the Virginia PTA; Dr. James Fetterman,

president of the Virginia Education Association; Mr. J.T. Kessler, government relations specialist for the Virginia School Boards Association; Dr. Lori McCullough, the executive director of the

[00:49:03] Virginia Association for Supervision and Curriculum Development; Ms. Elizabeth Parker, director of school counseling at Henrico County Public Schools and a member of the Virginia School Counselors Association; and alphabetically last but certainly not least, Dr. Alan Siebert, co-chair of the accreditation task force and superintendent of salem city public schools we certainly uh again thank you all for being here and know that the insights you all will provide will be certainly invaluable to this committee as we continue our review of the soa as i said i'm going to moderate

[00:49:39] the conversation and by way of allowing you some time to introduce yourselves i'm going to actually ask you to respond to a three-part question if you will just as the title of this presentation suggests we are really interested in hearing what you and your membership the membership in the organizations which you represent what you have noticed or noted as positive consequences negative consequences or unintended consequences from the 2017 standards of accreditation revision

[00:50:16] and so i'm going to ask you in the order that i introduced you alphabetical this time and then i'll switch it up a little bit later so ms alexander i'll ask you to start thank you so much for having us here today and for valuing parent voice and participation in the education of our children i want to start by thanking the board of education for your work so far and revising the standards of accreditation the simplified tier-based model and new emphasis on work-based readiness and the holistic measures that go beyond performance testing has been much appreciated and we value your continuous approach to feedback and improvement. The PTA does believe that no one

[00:50:53] single test or data point should be the sole determinant of student or school success and so we also want to express our thanks and support for your work that's shifting to a growth-based model. We recognize that this is a unique moment in time to be innovative and really measure the impact that distance learning is having on our students and talk about the ways that we can reward and and measure learning that's happening everywhere.

[00:51:16] As a positive consequence of the new growth model is that it's really been illuminating the disparities in academic achievement across various statistical subgroups. - Can you all hear me? Can anyone hear me or? - Can you hear me? - Yes, they can hear you. - Okay.

[00:51:36] So- - Keep going, Jenna. I think- - Okay. - I'm not sure, I think maybe Dr. Wilson is having some challenges, but I think everyone else can still hear you. - Okay. So we know that what I wanted to say is that We do think there's room to continue to add some equity measures into the standards of accreditation.

[00:51:53] We know that teacher diversity, school building maintenance, access to broadband, teacher ratios, teacher experience, parental involvement, they're all such critical factors in exploring a successful school learning climate. And we know that these are both challenging to measure and to fund, but we think that they're important and valuable factors to evaluate in the success of a school.

[00:52:13] As a negative outcome, that's really at the forefront of conversation right now is the use of absenteeism. Although this has historically been an indicator of academic success, there are a lot of ways that schools are taking attendance right now and accounting for seat time. We have students participating in virtual learning nonstop from 8:30 to 3:00 PM every day, four days a week, doing additional work as homework as the teachers try to meet those instructional hours.

[00:52:38] And while distance learning has been a great thing for some students, it's not sustainable for many. And so we encourage you to continue to evaluate whether or not absenteeism and attendance is the best way to measure engagement, opportunity, and the creation of a successful, diversified learning environment.

[00:52:55] As one unintended consequence, we very much appreciate and support your work to use multiple measures of student growth and the work that you're doing to reduce the number of SOLs and align them to the ESSA requirements. But we have observed that there is an increasing focus on more regular ongoing testing in the form of locally developed assessments.

[00:53:15] I know that there's federal requirements around this, but given the mental strain that testing can create for students. We hope that you'll continue to explore ways to use a wide variety of the different apps, games, programs, teacher, and locally developed assessments that track and measure student progress within the course of regular instruction as a factor of contributing data rather than referring only just to the end of year standards of learning as a sole proxy for success and growth.

[00:53:39] So thank you very much for the opportunity to comment. - Thank you, Ms. Alexandra. I'm sorry, I think I had a, I know I had a technical blip And so forgive me for blurting out, I wasn't sure what the issue was, but I appreciate you going forward with it and allowing me to catch up.

[00:53:58] So next I'll ask if Dr. Fetterman, would you mind sharing your observations? - Yes, gladly, thank you for the opportunity to address the positive and negative outcomes and unintended consequences of the 2017 SOA revisions.

[00:54:16] First of all, let me say that the VA is very appreciative the work done around the review of the SOAs and the consideration of these revisions by significant stakeholders like the VBA. So first I'd like to start with the positive outcomes from the 2017 SOA revisions. We do believe progress in assessing our students' learning in Virginia with the addition of growth factors and the expansion of alternative assessments in specific grades and subject areas.

[00:54:47] we we also believe there have been positive outcomes by expressing proficiency and growth through a combined rate that provides credit for students who pass sol tests in the content area and students who did not pass but met or exceeded progress benchmarks these are areas of focus our first significant steps to moving forward with multiple ways to measure our students growth and achievement we further believe the inclusion of the soa subgroup indicator has produced positive outcomes to address achievement gaps so even though the college career and civic readiness

[00:55:26] index will not be effective with accreditation year rating until 2022-23 ea believes this is important to measure the extent to which students successfully complete advanced coursework career and technical education coursework and credentialing and work base and service learning this indicator could be ambiguous nature school divisions and schools must determine how to identify best teaching practices to move students to become more college career ready and to create the system to

[00:56:02] measure college and career readiness this could be a good thing for those for those school divisions uh that have the capacity to accomplish this task the vea believes that student preparation for vocations and productive jobs should be a basic goal of education educational programs that assure equal opportunity for occupational growth should be developed for all students career and technical education is a major component of education so this time i'd like to pivot to some of the negative

[00:56:36] outcomes of the 2017 soa revisions a lot needs to be done around standardized testing not going far enough on alternative and performance-based student assessments continue to examine the reduction in the number of required standardized assessments we we also believe it's worth taking a deeper dive into student seat time and recommend attention to the following questions to address the seat time issue: What are the options for a flexible or staggered student schedule? What about rethinking what constitutes a school day and what defines an

[00:57:15] absence? What about defining and using methodologies that recognize student growth in lieu of student seat time and attendance related to requirements for accreditation? And what would this really look like? How has COVID-19 affected seat time and what reforms can we make in an innovative space to talk about what a school day looks like? Does seat time contribute to student achievement?

[00:57:44] The SOA does not include a school climate index. A school climate index could be considered for insertion into the SOA. The BDOE is currently administering school climate surveys to school divisions a growing body of empirical research shows that a sustainable positive school climate reduces dropouts and fosters youth development and academic achievement as well as knowledge skills and dispositions necessary for students to be responsible and productive members of society

[00:58:17] empirical research has also shown us that when school members feel safe value care for engage respected learning measurably increases and status staff satisfaction and retention are enhanced and lastly what are the unintended consequences of 2017 soa revisions some of these revisions to the soa may need more clarification or attention to the unintended consequence the chronic absenteeism indicator many times there are circumstances factors

[00:58:53] of absenteeism that are outside of the control of a school. School divisions are often required to figure out ways to identify, track, and correct students who are chronically absent. We believe the indicator to be uncontrollably to a major extent by schools. Many stakeholders have indicated that including chronic absenteeism penalizes schools of poverty and that the indicator is out of the school's control as to whether or not a child will come to school and

[00:59:29] there is no doubt the crisis the current crisis we face around covet 19 uh further activates this issue so the vea recommends further review of the chronic absenteeism and dropout rate indicators as a part of the accreditation in response to how schools will operate during and after the pandemic we encourage the use of school climate school engagement parent engagement and extracurricular

[00:59:58] participation thank you thank you dr fetterman next uh mr kessler good afternoon dr wilson and members of the committee uh let me say thank you on behalf of vsba for allowing me the opportunity to to speak with you about the uh the soas and in the work of the committee um dr pexton i i wish good health and a speedy recovery from whatever is ailing you today and and all of that so VSBA appreciates in this opportunity we have a very high

[01:00:35] standards for our employees and students and we appreciate the board taking this time to look at the SOA's and seeing the positive and negative and unintended consequences that they have had since 2017 a number of areas I was going to discuss have already been talked about uh by my colleagues on the panel so i'm gonna i'm gonna for the sake of time just address a few areas that uh of concern for us but we we do agree that covid19 presents a real opportunity to to look at the soas and and and get things um right uh in the future um we you know we're very we're we believe in assessment and accountability are a

[01:01:13] very necessary part um to providing quality education for for all students the assessment and accountability allow for continuous improvement within our divisions that allows us allows divisions to see where they're doing good where they need to improve and um you know the soas is providing that opportunity for for our divisions right now we really appreciate the local flexibility to implement methods of assessment um for locally verified credit how that has impacted uh our divisions and would definitely want to continue

[01:01:45] to highlight that positive. It provides accountability. It allows for growth to be shown over time, which we think is good rather than year by year. Again, it allows us to measure our students into our subgroups and to see where they are at this time and how we can address that so that all students have an equitable education. A few negatives that we've heard that I'm going to address is the chronic absenteeism. It is very concerning. We feel that this doesn't always factor

[01:02:19] in the socioeconomic factors that are causing a student to be absent from learning. The dropout rate calculation, again, it's using criteria we feel is not reflecting the socioeconomic factors again that uh that are that are uh involved in that decision that a student may make to drop out uh especially students that are adults and are 18 that they may be are the siphon slife students um who have little or no history of attending school uh you know using non-academic indicators

[01:02:56] uh in the soa can negatively impact the image of a school or a school division and we worry that sometimes this misses the positive academic progress that a school or school division is making when you focus on the absenteeism and the dropout rate. Lastly, I will just say that we have a concern that some SOLs used for accountability don't reflect the achievement that a student has made or that because it doesn't allow a student to demonstrate their

[01:03:31] mastery of the curriculum especially with our English language learner students they oftentimes can demonstrate mastery but because of whatever factor that it hurts them in taking a standardized test we feel that sometimes that this does not you know accurately reflect the the mastery that that these students have and with that I will just again say thank you for for inviting me here today on behalf of VSBA and I look forward to answering further questions as this panel continues.

[01:04:06] Thank you Mr. Kessler. Dr. McCullough. Good afternoon and thank you so much for including me and BASCD in this discussion. It's good to be with so many valued colleagues and people I respect and so it's a pleasure to just say ditto. I have heard many things already with which VASCD agrees and is aligned and so I won't repeat those things. I will say that I reached out

[01:04:40] to a bunch of our members and heard back again many of the things that have already been mentioned. I'll tell you a couple of themes that just kind of wrap up some of the input we got. I would preface this by saying I went on the assumption that any negative consequence is unintended so we do have um these sort of flip sides you know the good news bad news um kind of scenarios one thing that we heard from a lot of our members stated in slightly different ways but

[01:05:13] was definitely a theme is appreciation of the focus on career preparation um that that things have been a little bit more opened up with the profile of a graduate and and as the accreditation system evolves. We would like to see that continue. Now, the unintended consequence, at least I heard this from many of our members who work in high schools, is that how wonderful it is to be making policy and practice changes based on the assumption that we want our students to be not

[01:05:52] college or career ready, but college and career ready. And the attendant problem is that kids don't have enough flexibility in their schedules to pursue passions like the fine arts, for example. So some adjustment in that going forward would be helpful. Another theme I heard that has been mentioned by others on the panel is the focus on continuous improvement and a real shift away

[01:06:25] from feeling that accreditation was a punitive system towards one that is structured more along the lines of a continuous improvement system. Of course, the attendant problem is that people need really effective support when they are in those accreditation categories that require them to make certain improvements um we did here and i i don't mean to just be repetitive but i think this is a big issue so it's worth mentioning again is the the problems that come along with chronic

[01:07:04] absenteeism as a measure and issues related to seat time the definition of attendance is a good example i think for me of a lot of issues that are related to how we think about credit accreditation And I would just close by encouraging you to, at the same time, I know that you're in a bit of a policy box and that federal requirements and mandates don't leave our state with a lot of flexibility.

[01:07:39] But I would encourage you, instead of only thinking about revisions and adjustments and next steps in accreditation, to think about the next generation of accreditation and what that could look like.

[01:07:57] I think it's pretty clear to everyone, and others on the panel have mentioned, that the situation we're in does create opportunity for innovation. I think whether we take advantage of that opportunity or not, that when we come fully back to in-person school, school is going to look very different.

[01:08:16] I am hearing from my members about things that they're discovering that are pretty darn successful with kids in the environment that we're in. I talked to a high school principal the other day who said, you know, as difficult as this is, we have some students in our school who are pretty independent learners who are thriving in the virtual learning environment.

[01:08:41] And we're trying to figure out how when we come back to school in person, we can allow them to maintain that and not be boxed into things like seat time. So we do have opportunities to really think differently. And I would throw out three categories of thinking differently as I close here. Alignment, growth, and balance are my three watchwords today. Alignment meaning let's think going forward about how the things that we measure are the things that we care about the most.

[01:09:15] And so if that's higher level thinking, like the five C's, we need measures for those that measure those directly. Growth, I think we can do better than using SOLs as a proxy for growth. There are good growth measures, and especially in elementary reading and math, that's so critically important.

[01:09:36] I think in the next several years, we have got to figure out ways to measure real academic growth rather than only achievement. and then balance how do we how do we deal with the conundrum of we don't want to overburden schools with just being measured on everything we we want to take the measurements we need for accreditation and not a whole lot more and at the same time we want it to be a comprehensive well-rounded system so how do you how do you sit on that teeter-totter that's a huge question that I don't have an answer to but I do believe those are are great questions for us to be continuing

[01:10:14] to discuss so thank you again for the opportunity to participate and i'm learning a lot from everybody else already thank you dr mccullough especially for the watch words and the guiding questions um let's see that brings us to ms parker hi there thank you so much um good afternoon dr wilson and

members of the committee i want to thank the board of education for having vsta and myself here today we are very appreciative of ongoing inclusion of school counselors and and discussions about continued revisions to the standards of accreditation.

[01:10:54] This is something we live and breathe every day and really guides our practice from a day-to-day perspective in buildings. So we really appreciate the inclusion today. So a number of areas that I had on my list have already been addressed, obviously.

[01:11:11] It's what happens when your last name is towards the end of the alphabet. But I do want just to highlight a few things that we also would like to include part of this discussion um definitely want to highlight the thoughts and statements from my colleagues in terms of chronic absenteeism as a measurement or as a measure for the standards of accreditation also challenges related to seat time and the need for additional flexibility we really appreciate the focus of college and career readiness in terms of the 2017 revisions However, we do recognize in practical application that in order to participate in things such

[01:11:49] as work-based learning opportunities and some of these other service learning opportunities, we need some additional flexibility in terms of seat time in order to do so. So that was definitely one point I wanted to highlight that others spoke to as well. We also would like to recommend potential inclusion of growth measures in terms of social emotional learning and mental wellness into the standards of accreditation, nothing there really is little focus specifically on social emotional learning in our standards of accreditation. And I think as a result of COVID, we are definitely seeing how necessary these non-cognitive factors

[01:12:28] are in terms of academic success. So some sort of a focus in terms of growth measures of social emotional learning to be integrated into standards of accreditation and I do want to thank the standards of accreditation in 2017 and all those involved in revisions in really looking at specific graduation requirements and in really limiting the number of verified credits necessary in the advanced and the standard diploma the reduction from six to five verified credits for the standard diploma and the reduction from nine to five verified credits for the advanced studies diploma

[01:13:05] has significantly helped our students and encouraged more students to actively pursue the advanced studies diploma it's also allowed other students of maybe underrepresented populations the opportunity to graduate on time with their peers and has really helped us decrease our dropouts rates as well. So really appreciate that detailed focus and the reduction of the need of verified credits. Would like to continue seeing the focus of verified credits and SOLs and end

[01:13:40] of course assessments as well. In terms of unintended consequences, I have one specific unintended consequence and that is in regards to specifically the advanced studies diploma. i also reached out to colleagues across the state and overwhelmingly had concerns about the inclusion of a sequential elective requirement for the advanced studies diploma and how that is not working for our students it's not working well in practice um and and we've had a lot of overwhelming feedback from parents and students who are pursuing the advanced studies diploma

[01:14:18] and find that this new requirement from 2017 is limiting their opportunities for higher level coursework it's putting some constraints on their course selection and their academic career planning so we definitely did want to note that that that sequential elective requirement for the advanced studies diploma has in practice been very challenging for our students and has kept our students from pursuing

maybe coursework in a variety of content areas at a higher level so thank you that was it for us we really appreciate the focus of college and career

[01:14:53] readiness we really really appreciate the focus of vertical planning and college and career readiness being included at both the elementary the middle and the high school level because that's something that we we work hard to make sure happens so the inclusion of the academic career plan portfolio has been very positive across the commonwealth the renewed focus of the the career investigation course at the middle school level has also been positive we would love like everyone else just a little additional guidance and details in regards to computer

[01:15:26] science as a graduation meeting a graduation requirement in mathematics cte and in laboratory science that we've been kind of going back and forth across the division trying to figure out what that looks like so that was a plethora of different things but i really appreciate being part of this discussion um and i think that's it for school counseling thank you dr siebert dr willis and dr pexton members of the state board you know thank you for this invitation thank you for me last to follow these brilliant bright people with good good ideas um and and really i want to thank the the board in general for being committed to continuous improvement

[01:16:06] and for a willingness to get into the weeds you know this accreditation conversation gets deep and dense because it's complex i also thank the doe staff for always listening and thoughtfully considering ideas and issues such as the the presentations they gave at the beginning of your meeting just really just terrific staff and the work that they do i appreciate being invited to this the accreditation task force for reopening a school which was co-chaired by dr braebrand rose atkins and myself included people who are on this panel and shelly and her team and great doe people it was a distinguished group and the question was you know well gee how do we credit school next year and really our recommendation was if it wasn't a normal start way of accreditation that was been done that was appropriate

[01:16:44] but that group of people actually, you know, got deeper into accreditation, and our conversations really began to get at things that were beyond the scope of that task force that we felt were important for future consideration. So we sent a letter to Dr. Lane after that as separate from, and really the emphasis there was on student growth, and to really, really, truly start measuring reporting growth of individual students and the progress of individual schools, Not in a statistical sense, but in an authentic measure sense.

[01:17:14] And so then we got these great questions from the team, from Emily. And so I, like Lori and others, I reached out to instructional leaders throughout the region and beyond the region. And a lot of good things came from that. Most of them have already been said, but five C's came up over and over again.

[01:17:31] This great appreciation that we are focusing more on the skills that people have. But then the question was, well, how is that really being measured? You know, if that's important, then it probably needs to be, we need to figure out how we're going to get a handle on it.

[01:17:46] And if that's important enough to get a handle on it, then maybe we need to let go of some other handles. So that was a big part of it. The idea that the 2017 revision really was about being less punitive and more supportive, which was addressed, that there are still just too many requirements for graduation. You know, the whole diplomas in our nation and our Commonwealth are still based on the whole Carnegie Union approach.

[01:18:08] And there's just not enough time in the day. There needs to be some flexibility there. In terms of the unintended consequences, it really all boiled down to complexity. And here's the root problem, lots of input, but the real theme was complexity.

[01:18:30] It was like, wow, congratulations, Virginia. You had a 1990s accountability movement. You then adapted your system to bring in federal regulations of NCLB. you then had a 2000s push for college and career ready standards along the way you've made tweaks for tons of federal new requirements and um and and what one person went through is really powerful the soa has become a frankenstein and and so here we are looking at what happened the 2017 revisions contemplating like what might be the 2021 revisions and and maybe if if the root issue here with a lot of these unintended consequences is the complexity then maybe the wonderful powerful

[01:19:07] opportunity would be to start with a clean slate uh to you know as was really talked about jenna talked about pta about the innovation you know really not wasting this crisis and really taking a chance to to step back again it's great that y'all getting into the weeds to really understand the complexity and difficulty but maybe it's time to start with why and this is what virginia really did in the 1990s virginia said we have a problem to solve we have wide variance in quality of instruction throughout Virginia and and that was a significant problem and that was addressed through the accountability movement and we got to this standard level this minimum standard that the

[01:19:45] SOL test helped us achieve again people think I'm against the SOL test no they were a powerful tool to move and raise all the boats but now what we've been doing for really closing on 30 years now is tweaking and reinventing and modifying and and through all these good intentions the biggest thing is the complexity piece. Now, again, we don't want a clean slate to take us back to the hobby teaching of the 70s and early 80s. We don't want to do as what legislators are afraid of that we'll get back to the wild, wild west. That's not the issue. That problem has been solved. We have a minimum standard and we have a way to assess it. But, you know, maybe we have the opportunity here

[01:20:24] to just think really big and start with why. What matters to Virginia now? And I think we talked about the five c's and the career and technical education all these things matter if these are things that matter how do we actually then measure them and then and and again we've got to think about the federal piece but let's not start inside the federal box let's build and consider what could be in virginia and then figure out how we weave in pieces of the federal box but i i think we keep coming at from the lens of what we've been doing what we've been doing what we've been doing and and conditions have changed so wildly even more so in the last eight months that we really

[01:21:03] have an opportunity to start with what matters and and and work backwards uh to figure out how to get there and so i think it's a very exciting time you know we in salem city schools have just resolved never to waste a crisis and we have leveraged a whole host of changes and the things we're going to do with the school division of innovation opportunity is going to be powerful i think the state board and the great team that has been assembled the department is positioned to do the exact same thing start with why do something that really matters to and then work backwards into planting new garden.

[01:21:39] - Thank you, Dr. Siebert. Thanks to all of you for your remarks, for identifying very clearly and so thoughtfully what you see as positive, negative, and unintended consequences, and then key questions that we might ask. Really appreciate that.

[01:21:55] This next question I'm going to throw open to the group whomever might like to chime in with a response. The question is, what policies and practices have your members seen change or actually put into practice as a result of the 2017 SOA?

[01:22:13] What have you seen change policy or practice wise? Anyone who'd like to jump in? And I can't see everybody on the screen, so you may have to verbalize your desire to jump in. - Oh, I'll go, this is James Fetterman. The policies that we've seen changed, One, protecting planning time, reduction in testing, instructional practices around subgroups, transitions from SOL to performance-based assessments.

[01:22:44] Those are just a few. - Would you run that list again? - Absolutely. So protecting planning time, a reduction in testing, instructional practices around subgroups, and a transition from SOL testing to performance-based assessments.

[01:23:10] Okay. And this is Laurie McCullough. I will say those of you who know VASCD know that we are largely about professional learning and high quality professional learning. And so I want to just tag on to that comment to say that what we are finding is that the opportunity for school divisions to lead their teachers through the process of designing and scoring performance assessments in a reliable and valid way is one of the most powerful professional learning experiences that a lot

[01:23:48] of teachers have had in their careers. So it has been in many school divisions an opportunity to really invent tools that push student performance forward on authentic skills. And just having the window open you know to be able to do that work has empowered school division leaders to to take their teachers to a really high level of professional learning and it's changed and so I can I can think of examples of specific schools and school divisions where I think has really changed

[01:24:27] instruction starting with the the design of performance assessment and leveraging that to change practice. This is JT. Last month, you all received the task force report from the VSBA Students in Schools in Challenging Environments Task Force that looked at a number of practices that were underway across Virginia. That was not a complete, you know, comprehensive list of practices going on, but there are two, I believe, that answer this question. There are many of them,

[01:25:03] But to the continue that they're using at the school division level come community and family engagement, you know, surveys to see how the school is responding to the concerns of parents and and and working on that that that study is in the report it references Arlington City schools.

[01:25:21] And their survey process. And then secondly, just the number of divisions that have created equity policy or equity officers and how that is addressing you know, the accountability method that we want everybody to, you know, an equitable education for all students and how our divisions are holding themselves accountable by through these practices.

[01:25:46] Thank you. Anyone else? I echo all of those. I think that there has been a renewed emphasis on career technical education, which is which is good, I think, has led to collaborations with the Department of Labor and with local businesses.

[01:26:01] And, you know, we actually, that's where we worked last General Assembly session to really make the case that, you know, meaningful workplace-based experience is probably a really good preparation for the stand diploma as well. So those are, those are all really good things. I think it's also concurrent with the fact that the free market is driving individuals and families to see that there are other ways to win.

[01:26:22] And those things are all coming together nicely. But I think kind of what JT was just alluding to, which, again, we're probably Jamel's part of your next question, is as we've been building out these newer, better opportunities that go beyond the minimum, the gap for equity is widened.

[01:26:43] Because as you're working really, really hard to help kids get to the minimum, that requires extra time and effort. And you already have a diploma set that's so jam-packed, there's not much time or elbow space in there, and you very quickly take that last little slice of time and effort to reinforce, and these students aren't getting to build the passion projects and have as many opportunities and experiences.

[01:27:06] So the equity piece is huge. So, Alan, I'm glad you mentioned that, and I am going to come to that question about equity and addressing and supporting socioeconomically disadvantaged students and ELLs as it relates to what you've done.

[01:27:26] But let me make sure that there aren't others who may want to talk about policies and practices that you all have seen added or adjusted as a result of the 2017 SOA. if not then let's go on and pivot now I have one quick comment yeah absolutely um we have seen a number of school divisions across the Commonwealth who have crafted or revised policies in regards to school-based mental health and school counseling professionals in general to assist in these broad college

[01:28:04] and career readiness initiatives that we've been very pleased with to limit or reduce the case loads of school counselors limit and reduce the ratio of school counselors to students as well to help to help really meet these goals and these strategies that we are suggesting so that is definitely something we've seen from Virginia School Counseling Association there's been a number of policies from different divisions across the Commonwealth that are recognizing the role that school counselors play that is directly aligned with our standards of accreditation.

[01:28:37] - Thank you for that, Elizabeth. So let's talk a little bit more then, if you will, as panelists, talk a little bit more about what you have seen your members and colleagues doing to support students in this area of those who have needs socioeconomically, or ELLs, and this gap that Alan talks about, the equity gap that we see potentially widening many cases absolutely widening. What are we doing? What are folks doing to try to address that? Alan,

[01:29:16] I don't know if you want to start maybe and expound a little bit more and then others jump in. Well, the way I see it being addressed in our city actually highlights the persistent inequities in more rural divisions. Our equity effort is because we are a 14 and a half square mile city with a robust fiber backbone and great partnerships with different vendors we were we've been able to drive up to 99 connectivity and we've also had previously put a device in every child's hands so we had already given all kids the same tool we already made great efforts in getting them

[01:29:55] reliable access to the internet to continue to do remote learning in the spring and to continue this fall and but that that is still the ongoing need because even as you link it takes a lot of these people uh again the counselors just always become the nexus of information for for need and and then the it people to connect these people to get them connected but even if you get them with a low cost device or a low cost service or you're in fact picking up the cost for the service um then then more families are coming in so there's this real the real issue there but my heart breaks uh for the localities where you know there is no fiber into that community there's not even a a a 3g

[01:30:34] signal uh into that into that part of that county and so the the access gap i think is is is really really significant thank you anyone else yes this is uh james from the vea i one of the things for us uh this has been uh more concentration on instruction to subgroups to a certain degree uh you know the vea believes that the revisions uh to the soas have been sensitive to economically

[01:31:09] disadvantaged students and english language learners so we need to make sure that we review the certain aspects of ell and with that uh recently the video we identified several improvements and adjustments that could be made to the soas to address clarity in the areas of student achievement uh school and instructional leadership and school accreditation so with that being said we you know we agree with the videoe's recommendation that additional clarity may be necessary for the standards of accreditation to ensure current practice aligns with the intent

[01:31:46] of the Virginia's administrative code around teacher ratios and planning periods. So, you know, we are committed to working with the VDOE and the board to collaborate further on additional areas of clarity to address the revised SOA's intent in these areas and also to revise the SOA language which to require students to take in the course tests needed to meet the assessments and accountability requirements under ESSA and any other tests as may be needed for verified credit.

[01:32:20] But, and lastly, to clarify the language to specify that multiple performance assessments are required to award a verified credit and that we revisit the number of verified credits needed for graduation for students transferring in during their 10th grade year or at the beginning of their 11th grade year.

[01:32:41] So that concludes our thoughts on that section. - Thank you, Dr. Fetterman. - Jamel, if I may, one of the things that Dr. Fetterman just pointed out that really went on a miss. In terms of English learners, there have been advancements in assessment.

[01:32:59] You know, the WIDA and all those type of things have advanced, there's newer tools, and we're actually looking at individual children and where they are and where they've been and where they've come and we're reporting that out. That is what has to happen with assessment. If we're really gonna make progress with other reporting groups, if we're really gonna get down into moving along students and other reporting groups, we had to have new tools that allow us to look at individual kids, where they were, where they've been, how we got them there and then aggregate that data up.

[01:33:29] - You know, I'd like to chime in and second some of these thoughts that have been shared from the parent perspective. - We definitely have seen an increase in focus on differentiated instruction to meet individual student needs. And as we start to look at that though, there's exactly to what Dr. Siebert had shared regarding complexity is we've made a very focused effort over the past two years to share with our parent community how to understand the standards of accreditation and to access the school quality profiles.

[01:33:59] But yet when we talk with the parents, we still feel that they don't understand that it's based on a growth model. They think it's whether or not you pass the SOL test. There doesn't seem to be a strong understanding of what happens if your school is not accredited or if you were at level two or at level three, what should as a parent, what should I expect to see happen from my school division, from my principal or from the state?

[01:34:22] There's not a strong understanding of that across the parent community. And I think as we see our families at home trying to support their students in this virtual environment, it reinforces how

critically important it is have meaningful two-way communication between parents and the schools related to the assessment and how we really reach out to some of our particularly economically disadvantaged and english language learner students and ensuring that in particular that there's spanish translation access in that we've heard a lot of concerns from the special education community that they

[01:34:56] sometimes don't feel that the tests are designed to meet some of their adaptive needs and test them to the point that they really reached the curriculum and to that same thought right our english language learners if there's opportunities when they are still struggling with english to test them on the curriculum and content in their home language that could be an advantage to really lift them up academically and reflect what they've managed to master in the curriculum thank you i would just this is laurie mccullough i would just tag on to that um just to reinforce that the idea that we

[01:35:32] might have real growth measures that would show us the progress of individual students from year to year and we could look at a student and tell if they had made more less or pretty much exactly one year's worth of progress in one year of instruction that is an equity not solution but but certainly a tactic or a strategy for addressing equity we have students who are who are at at risk and who are behind academically but who are growing at more than a year's worth

[01:36:09] of academic progress every year and the growth measures that we have now are proxies for that but they don't tell us that student by student so to get that information i would think would be hugely valuable in informing our equity efforts and the only other thing i would say i'm not sure it's so targeted to this policy discussion, but I think it's interesting in response to your question about what practices are we seeing. I'm talking to lots of teachers and principals these

[01:36:42] last eight months who have, because of the crisis we're in, been making extraordinary efforts to connect with their kids. And you all have heard the same examples I have, I'm sure. I was talking to a principal today, he was asked, well, what do you do when kids don't show up for virtual instruction? When somebody logs on to teach their class and only half the students are there. And he said, well, I get in my car and I go to their house and I knock on the door and I nicely say, hi, do you need some help getting online? And when teachers and principals and other staff are doing

[01:37:21] those kinds of things, what I'm hearing and what I'm learning is that they are learning things about their students and their families that they never knew before, even when those students were in those classrooms with them every day. And so I think there is an acknowledgement of that, at least among our members, the ones I'm talking to about this, that there are some of these strategies that even when we're back in school, if things ever look, you know, sort of like they used to again, and everybody's showing up every day, that some of these things that they have done

[01:37:58] as a result of the crisis, they will continue to do because there's huge value added in those practices. Thank you for that. I appreciate hearing you describe that scenario, Lori, because it is important, I think, as we learn more, that we not shelve what we have now seen and just leave it there, but rather that we use this situation that we find ourselves in as a springboard to move

[01:38:31] forward, not just to settle back, I guess, on our haunches where we were, but really to use it as a springboard. So I'm going to maybe pause right here and ask committee members if there are questions that you would pose to any member or members of the panel that you'd like to have some feedback on.

[01:38:59] Dr. Wilson, this is Dr. Pexton. I don't have any additional questions. I just wanted to take an opportunity to thank the panel. I've found this session to be extremely informative and your feedback is very valuable.

[01:39:17] I've got a litany of notes over here that I know that I've taken based on some of your comments. And so I just wanted to take the opportunity to thank the panel. - Thank you. Dr. Duran, did I see you, your square light up a moment ago?

[01:39:35] - Yes, you did. I was gonna do the same thing and thank everyone for their thoughtful feedback and suggestions. And I did want to ask a couple of, a theme I heard from a few individuals was around attendance and truancy. And I just wanted to pick a little bit more at that. I know Dr. Siebert, Dr. McCullough, I remember mentioned it. So I would love to, not putting them on the spot, but I would love to hear a little bit more about that in terms of, not the issue, we've heard the issue. And I think a lot of us on the committee certainly understand that, but just what are some suggestions and possible solutions you would see in terms of that? Whoever would like to go. Thank you.

[01:40:13] Dr. Gron, going back to the revisions of 2017, I think what was appreciated was that there was an effort to look for an indicator that was not so completely statistically correlated with poverty. And so the part of the reason you're hearing the chronic absenteeism piece coming from all directions is because it's a challenge in every school district and every community. And so it is definitely less correlated. So I think that was, I remember at that time, effort was, you know, we have so many measures that are so correlated with socioeconomic status.

[01:40:46] What are some other measures we can bring to bear? And so I think it comes down to, you know, really, as you heard Dr. Fetterman and others talk about the importance of climate and culture and those kinds of things, that absolutely, you want to play at schools where kids want to be, and you want to get them there, and you need people out doing them. But, you know, we, just like we need more counselors doing things, we, visiting teachers and school social workers, all these needs are so real to go out and get the experiences that Lori just spoke to.

[01:41:14] So maybe I don't, I think attendance is still a huge factor. I think that factor should be triangulated with the expectation that it's measured and reported, that it is maybe not become, maybe it's not a makes you red, yellow or green, but that it is a factor, an indicator that is looked at, that it's, you know, something that you can either celebrate or slow down and look at or learn more about but then i also think there's an opportunity and the general we've asked general assembly for i'm my 15th year superintendent in salem and i've asked many different legislators over many different years to try to strengthen um some compulsory attendance laws and there just really hasn't been a stomach for that and that then puts schools in a real difficult spot this

[01:41:54] is important we absolutely are committed teaching learning we want the kids there too but the tools we have for the persistently absent families um is is very hard and it just really burns our judges. We now have judges who are participating in Zoom meetings because they're committed to sending a message that will be faster than trying to run them through a process. And so I celebrate our juvenile court judges for what they do. That's a generous investment of time, but that's another indicator that the tools that are there really aren't working. Okay, Dr. Siebert. Dr. McCullough, do you have anything to add? I appreciate it. I can't ever say anything better than Alan Siebert

[01:42:32] says it, so I won't try to repeat. But the only thing I would add, and I don't have, I wish I had a solution to this. I don't. I've barely well articulated the problem, I think. But I do see this as being related to the whole issue of competency-based instruction and competency-based learning. One of the things we talked about in the accreditation task force a little bit is,

[01:43:00] So what is a school day? If you really are committed to competency-based learning and getting away from measuring how much credit you've earned by how many hours you've sat in your seat, and you've got a variety of students in a class, and some of them can pass the end-of-course test the second week of school, then if they don't show up a few days because they're doing something independent or they're working on a performance assessment,

[01:43:30] Do you count them absent? And especially, I think, as we see what these hybrid models end up looking like, I am going to predict that even when we get to a situation where everybody can come back to the school building full time, we will find that there are some kids who maybe that's not how we best serve them.

[01:43:56] Maybe we'd best serve them some other way, which begs the question of, so what's a school day and what's an absence? And so I think, though I don't have a solution, I think the solution lies in connecting this question to the question of how we measure performance and competency.

[01:44:16] Going right back to the original idea we started with a half an hour ago of what matters. if it's the five C's, if it's those transferable skills, those life important essential skills, and if students are demonstrating those somewhere else than in the classroom on a piece of paper, is there a way they can get credit for both their learning and their attendance? I wish I had an answer. I know what the question is, that's about all. I think that very is actually helpful, not necessarily a complete solution, but it's a direction that we need to be thinking about

[01:44:53] And Dr. Siebert said the same thing, very connected to what he said, to the notion of let's pay attention to attendance. We want to make sure that we're not having students that are not, are just falling to the cracks again. But what do we put our priorities into in terms of how we're monitoring and assessing our accreditation?

[01:45:11] And I think that that's an area that I hope our committee members will look at differently with both veins. You know, not to throw out one, not to say we're not paying attention to attendance because there are some challenges that if we do take that off, are some students I believe that won't be paid attention to and haven't been in the past and we've seen that and so how do we balance that approach and I think your framework of thinking is a helpful one to guide us in that next step so thank you for that and if anyone else wanted to comment that welcome as well but I appreciate the two of you commenting on that Dr. Wilson I'll

[01:45:44] turn it back to you any other panelists like to chime in on that particular question I would just like to say Dr. Wilson that I am very appreciative of everyone's point of view and how we're coming to the table today and the feedback that we're getting especially what I'm taking away from this are the the guidance of these the thoughtful people who came to our table today thank you guests for doing that the watch words the guiding questions Lori said alignment growth and balance

[01:46:18] and the complexity of the SOAs, what matters, the five C's and someone said that what we, our priority is what we should measure so I thank you for each of that and I'd like to add to that question that

Dr. Duran brought up is he was asking about the different ways of measuring the chronic absenteeism and how we're going to do that. I'd like to know what are some of your thoughts about moving forward into the future of new tools and new assessments for the different subgroups what are some of your thoughts about moving into the future for it for the subgroups

[01:46:56] anyone please jump in alan i was trying to give equity a voice to other panelists um this is something that you know dr lane and i have talked about for well over a decade probably 15 years now and so there's no shortage of ideas and opinions here but it really comes back to big picture again we were dealing with a system that was built in the 90s to solve a problem in the 80s and it was built in a way that used the tools of the time to solve the problem of the time and and

[01:47:35] those are still tools in the toolbox but over the past nearly 30 years there's a whole bunch of new tools available and to be able to bring those to bear to instead of drawing a pint of blood out of every patient on the 180th day to see their blood chemistry to instead do a lot of just finger sticks all along the way and we have the tools now we have a student test identifier so we can aggregate these little measures of individual children up because every child has the student test identifier and so it we can now begin using these more diagnostic tools different tools for different

[01:48:09] children different circumstances and still aggregate them up and show what we're doing and and and be absolutely accountable for every child and and so until we bring new tools to bear statewide I think it'd be very difficult to accomplish. So Alan, I'm going to push you a little bit on that. You know, the analogy you used was we, in the 90s, we built a tool to built a tool to address the issues of the 80s, right? So if we take your idea, this idea, and think about, so what is the problem we, that we can, what is the tool we can build right now

[01:48:47] that solves the anticipated problems that we would see in 2030, 2035, right? So i'm curious as you've described you know the diagnostic tool all of that if you and others can talk a little bit about then what level of agility needs to be present in order for us to continue to make adjustments all along the way so originally when the problem was wild inconsistency the wild wild west hobby teaching all those things the way to raise all boats was to create

[01:49:22] a minimum standard and raise everybody up to that and and so the tools of fixed response assessments back even pre-computers now we're talking bubbles all that it did that but the other fact truth was there were still better ways to assess back then but that was the affordable way to do it for million plus students and in millions upon millions of tests so there was the the need and the practicality and the affordability but really what that led us to was an accreditation system that came in the late 90s early 2000s that was based on percentages what percent of your children achieved this score how many children achieve this percentage of percentages and the teachers in the classroom loving and teaching kids don't don't teach percentages they teach individual children

[01:50:01] and so the this desire to show that yes this child still is below 400 on this test but this child over the past three years has made six years worth of growth and by golly we want to celebrate that against next year these tools are now available but um it is it's it's a different person and this goes back to the complexity piece, Dr. Wilson, is if we just layer this on to what we're already doing, we have just made Frankenstein lumber that much worse. And so this is why, you know, most of the people in the field are saying, we appreciate this effort, we appreciate this work, but maybe it's

[01:50:37] time to get a fresh sheet of paper, determine what Virginia, what matters to Virginia, and then figure out how we're going to assess it. And I think what matters to Virginia, coming back to the reporting group piece is every single child making progress every single year. And even those of us who are teaching very early in SOL has believed that this child might not pass the test this year, but they will be better off for having me because I'm a good teacher. And I still believe that is the passion that our profession has. Dr. Wilson, may I provide some more information about measures of growth? Sure. So, I mean, Dr. Sieber, you're absolutely correct. You know, the measure of

[01:51:17] growth we use currently is probably not the most robust. I think it's clear in the 2017 SOA that the board wanted to make sure that we did value growth and that we tried to give credit for students who maybe didn't pass but were making progress.

[01:51:32] We have been working on a more robust measure of growth. Had we been able to test in the spring of '20, we would have been able to implement that measure so that we would have been able to look at the measurement of growth from year a year um you know we're looking at what we do since we were not able to test but i didn't want the committee to be aware that this is something we've been aware of and we have been working on a different solution um but um we we were hampered by the fact that we were not able to test in spring of 20. thank you dr wilson thank you for that shelly i'm in dr wilson can i jump in certainly

[01:52:14] as a board member but not a committee member i've been enjoying listening to all of this wisdom and grateful to everybody um uh the uh you know i'm teaching ed policy to grad students this year um at mason and many of my students are practicing teachers or folks who are really engaged already in the system and i try to teach our accreditation system to it to them you know what we did in the 2017 revision and let's just say i agree with you on the complexity item and the truth is we had many goals we would achieve in that revision and we did not put simplicity or

[01:52:54] transparency up there as one of our identified goals and and if i had it to do over again i would have us go back and do that especially i can just imagine to make this thing make sense to parents i you know many of us who've been steeped in it for for many years now barely understand it so i cannot imagine how parents could possibly understand it so i do think that the complexity issue is huge and i think how do we measure growth well is huge also and i know that um shelley's been doing her best to wrestle essentially a measure that a test system that

[01:53:31] was not designed to measure growth go wrestle it to the ground and make it work well as a growth measure but fundamentally you know we can do a lot better and the on the absenteeism I hear the comments that you know we really are hoping I mean I wonder it'd be interesting to look and I'd love to have the department tell us at some point are the schools that are showing up as level 3 on absenteeism the same schools are showing up on other criteria anyway so it's not really adding very much or is it identifying different schools who need intervention but but I but I do worry

[01:54:10] that it is a little bit just beating up in folks that we're beating up otherwise and yet I I don't so all of that said I'm gonna challenge you to tell me why a whole clean slate approach makes since now and I really feel like we've barely had a chance for this system to be experienced yet and especially with COVID interruption but even before COVID we're really still just at the beginning of this and we do know from the last experience that these you know major revisions

[01:54:46] can take five years right so maybe it's time now to start a revision with a 2027 target day or something like that but uh but um but um i i just worry that doing anything hugely different now you know will just make it more complex because all you all your colleagues who are finally beginning to understand it and all of us are finally beginning to understand it um um uh will just be thrown um um thrown askew again so uh so i you know tell me tell me should we but and then maybe covetous the chance when we should still just throw it all out and do more

[01:55:25] you know maybe maybe we didn't the fundamentally the 2017 wasn't good enough that we ought to throw it out before we all waste our time getting used to it and start all over but i i'd be interested in you all's thoughts on that and um and if i'm right that we shouldn't do huge revisions now you know give us the tinkering ideas so i'm going to start with dr fetterman then i'll go to dr mccullough Mr. Kessler and Dr. Siebert so you guys remember that order and Ms. Alexander I see your hand as well you guys remember that order because I will likely forget Dr. Fetterman yes thank you so much

[01:56:01] Dr. Wilson I think that we need to look at this in in some context of what opportunity we currently have with this situation and I'm just reminded of of being child driven and data informed and this COVID situation has allowed us to really look at ADM and seat time in ways that we've never had to look at before. And I'm just reminded that there are children who are doing the work,

[01:56:35] getting the task done, but they're still expected to be in the seat to be counted. But I'm just reminded that we're asking children to to be elevated based upon x y and z and if the child is able to receive the instructional methodology that's been put before them without actually having to sit in the seat but they can show the evidence-based mastery of whatever the skill and the concept that was taught or introduced they might not need all of that scaffolding to do and And I think that we're missing an opportunity

[01:57:15] to really move children further along in this situation. Whereas if we were in a classroom setting, we would probably keep everybody moving slowly, but making progress. But right now we have some students who could pass the end of the year test right now.

[01:57:33] And those kids should not be penalized because they are not actually clicking in to be counted, but yet the work is being done. So I am just reminded that to look at this as an opportunity to really say what we could do based upon the cards that were being dealt.

[01:57:53] So I go back to being child-driven. If we're really doing what's right and what's best for every single child, regardless of where they're coming from, regardless of their zip code, regardless of all of those things, the data is gonna speak for itself.

[01:58:08] so if they're doing geometry 5.1 and they can totally master that objective and not have to show up give them their credit and keep it moving i you know that's that's my that's my story and i approve that message that's a good message i approve it too i think i would say uh two things uh in response to miss holton's question one is uh i i don't think that the idea of rethinking

[01:58:42] the whole accreditation system is necessarily equivalent to let's throw everything out. I do think that, you know, obviously we have to continue to have policy. We have to build on good work of the past. We have to, you know, we can't just have a tight accreditation system one day that's written into policy and nothing the next day and say, oh, well, we're working on it. You know, give us time while we

dream. We can't do that. So what I would encourage is for the board to proactively start thinking about what is our new definition of what a good school is.

[01:59:22] Our old definition of what a good school is, is bottoms in chairs for the right number of hours and lots of kids getting high scores on SOL tests. It's different now and we need to think about how we are going to articulate that difference. So we have some goals in mind or some directions in mind. And then as you're tweaking, if tweaking is what has to be done, tweak towards that goal and ask yourself if each revision and each tweak you're making is getting you closer to the big

[02:00:01] changes you want that are really going to matter. And that is, are we getting closer to measuring the five c's are we providing a more well-rounded picture of what a good school is and really i don't say this because i want to see everybody roll their eyes and groan but but honestly i'm reminded of some of the work that the sol innovation committee did several years ago some of this work is in those reports um there are some examples there there are some recommendations there that are coming to mind for me as we have this conversation and so i think that's maybe worth

[02:00:40] revisiting or maybe some parts of it might be worth revisiting thank you for the opportunity to respond yeah i'm just going to echo a number of things that have already been said in regards to this but you know all of us as educators um if covet has taught us anything all of us as educators remember students who could have done very well outside of the classroom and you know revisiting and looking, you know, for ways that we can provide students with choice of how they receive their education in an accountable way. I think that, you know, Dr. Wilson, you said, what does

[02:01:17] the 2035 school look like? I believe you said earlier. Well, I think that we're learning a lot of valuable lessons from this current period that we're going through of what a 2035 school could look like and it is it's individually focused on the student and finding ways to make sure that each student is provided with an equitable education in a way that best suits their individual learning needs so i mean i i think that the sky's the limit on this and and uh you know and maybe there is a silver lining with covid that we're learning some we're learning some lessons that we

[02:01:51] can apply in the future to uh you know to to make a world-class public education system attainable for all virginian students and please know that we absolutely trust you and appreciate you this is a very very strong state board with a remarkably strong department rich with practitioners who get the issues and so we trust you to figure out the timing as to when things fall we all understand from our organizations their seasons and cycles so um no i think well and i also appreciate what staff did the presentations at the beginning from shelly and her team show that they've been listening to what we've talked about since 2017 they didn't wait till now to ask they've been

[02:02:29] listening to the conversations over the past three years and so they have a really good handle on some of the low-hanging fruit that you can tweak and improve but i don't know you know where the state board is in strategic planning and all these different things that happen but i i think to put a a process in place and a marker in the sand would be absolutely important to begin rethinking because back to dr wilson's question about the school of 2035 what it will not be is it will not be same there will not be sameness there will not be sameness in seat time they're not the same as in requirements every same assessment sameness is going to go away all these things that we do

[02:03:04] where spanish three and chemistry both require 50 minutes 180 times none of that is going to apply and by the time we get there bring us home ms alexander i wanted to reiterate and support many of

the things that have just been said and bring it really back to a student perspective you know we were talking about how do we engage some of these low-income learners or the english language learners so i have i'll make it really personal i have a fifth grader and i have an eighth grader they've been doing map testing this past week and so i've been you know here as a parent helping them and watching that progress and i think that sometimes it's important for us to

[02:03:41] remind ourselves that the student perspective ownership and engagement is really critical to that process both in them personally understanding their growth and immediately instantaneously having that data so they can understand how they did compared to others and where they have opportunity to grow but also allowing them to choose some of the curriculum tools like we know that some students really thrive in some of these game-based learning apps that they do on their tablets and on their phones but then when you sit them down to do the map testing the concept of that and the structure of it is not advantageous for them to show their mastery of curriculum and i think that there's opportunities to allow our students to compact

[02:04:19] the curriculum and select places where they would want to do for instance a virtual instruction versus in person for instance like my son loves to read right he would be just fine doing english at home on his own time in his own space but he's desperately sad that he's not in tech ed learning to do woodworking with the teacher right so there's opportunities where every student has and I it may be a stretch too far to think about it as a college-based selection where at these secondary levels you allow them to pick and choose you know the different ones and some are offered online and some are offered in person but I think there's opportunity there for student autonomy and

[02:04:55] choice and engagement in their own growth and and allowing them to to own that process so thank you all so much uh i have can i i'm sorry can i can i just ask one thing uh i apologize i'm on through through my um i've launched through the internet so i'm not able to read but i did just want to um draw our attention to one thing regardless of any changes that occur something that we've heard over and over again from parents and students is the idea that currently the requirements for a student to earn a diploma in virginia um are those that are in fact when the student enters ninth grade

[02:05:33] for the first time so as we continue to revise what those requirements look like we would really appreciate any consideration for student choice in terms of the diploma requirements that they would choose to pursue if diploma requirements are revised if that makes sense so a student entering ninth grade for the first time in 2018 2019 may find themselves more likely to graduate with diploma requirements that were part of a any revision moving forward and we would like for them to have that option to um be able to make that choice um instead of being tied to the diploma

[02:06:13] requirements that were or to the soa that was their program of studies when they entered high school thank you i appreciate that elizabeth um and thank you all for your your remarkable insights and sharing those with us we have just about three or four minutes left and so before we wrap up I'd like to just open the floor to committee members or board members who would elevate topics or further questions we don't have time for a conversation around those but it would be useful for us to hear what comments or topics or questions this conversation today has

[02:06:52] elevated for you so I know that Dr Duran has to sign off exactly at four so Dr Duran if you have anything would certainly appreciate hearing your voice at this time. Well a couple of things I did raise in my question of course is the issue around the attendance. I want us to look more carefully at that and in

the previous conversation where I heard from the VDOE staff about Dr. Living Rider that they are looking at the beginning phase of our SLIFE and SIFE students so that's very important and I really appreciated Dr. McCullough raising the notion about our SOL Innovation Committee, I was on that with her several years ago. And I think that might be

[02:07:30] another thing for all of us to raise back and look at some issues there. So those are the top ones off the top of my head. And I want to thank everyone for coming today and sharing your different perspectives. This is so powerful for us to hear from everyone and meaningful.

[02:07:46] And I want to thank our chair, Dr. Paxton, a while back a few months ago who were outlining how we were going to move forward. This was one area that she worked on and leading and we all provided feedback and she made it happen for us to get panelists and this is the second time that we've had this great panel to listen to so thank you everyone you're on mute dr wilson thank you yes anyone else have comments topics or questions that you'd like to enter into the the conversation

[02:08:18] for another time uh dr wilson i i would just like to put in this space um as we continue to do the work um i just want to applaud uh the board's action in adopting a statement regarding systemic racism racial justice and education and you know with that being said the vea believes that education is a way of gaining an awareness of the world's cultural diversity you know in the way in which we live so regardless of how we're looking at going forward all students should be encouraged

[02:08:53] to develop pride in their own cultural legacy um and to develop an appreciation of common humanity shared by all people of the earth and and i think with that being said whatever is done remember our children are like credit cards we can pay now or we can pay later thank you dr fetterman absolutely thank you anything else from uh go ahead mr gecker or president gecker i should say no mr gecker or dan is fine as you know you know it's always wrong to start a comment

[02:09:29] by saying i don't have anything really enlightening to add but here it goes uh first i'd like to thank everybody for doing this uh you know for me it's a great opportunity to hear the different perspectives uh and for the board you know the purpose of this committee is exactly i think what y'all are talking about doing not to wholesale scrap where we are but to tinker around the edges and begin to bend the arc toward what we want it to be uh you know one of the criticisms we've had of the sol system put in place 20 plus whatever it is years ago is that they put it in place with

[02:10:09] certain goals in mind and then never went back and looked at what impact it was having and therefore never adjusted things honestly i think educationally in virginia we would be in a much different place if our predecessor boards had taken the time you know as that system was being put in place and as it began to operate to make certain you know strategic changes in it uh to lessen some of the negatives and perhaps heighten some of the positives you know as Dr. Siebert mentioned it did lift all boats to a certain extent but it also had some significant negative consequences our goal as a board is you know I think as has been mentioned to you know

[02:10:47] get every child in the commonwealth to be educated up to their potential and how we get there is still obviously you know after all this time on this board you know it never ceases to amaze me how complicated it is to get what is you know a seemingly simple statement you know teach our children well right and that's all we want to do to make that simple statement turn into practice and yet we have a legion of well-meaning and smart people you know addressing this issue uh you know as a board i think it would be fair to say that we would move toward a more competency

[02:11:23] based education system but how we go from where we are to where we want to be is really you know the heart of this issue. And from my perspective, I'd like to, again, thank Dr. Pexton for leading this committee.

[02:11:40] You know, the goal is as we put things in place, let's go through that process of continually analyzing what it's doing. Again, not with the idea, Ms. Holton, of starting a new five-year process that gets us into 2027 and a new system, but just making those changes along the edges, the incremental changes so that we begin to nudge ourselves toward, you know, a system that will benefit all of our kids. You know, even things like the chronic absenteeism. And I know, you know, there is some pushback on that from the field. But the goal there was to not just focus on

[02:12:15] the top 75%, if you will, to get the passing accreditation. It was to say to the divisions, we care as a board about every child in the Commonwealth, even those we're not reaching today currently. And we have seen, particularly in Southwest, when we went to visit there, are some remarkable and fairly cost-effective programs to dramatically reduce the chronic absenteeism rate. You know, very inspirational and really kind of cool to see. And now it's not one size is going to fit all, but I'm confident that the local divisions will have ideas about

[02:12:49] how to address that as time goes on. And nobody, I think, underestimates the importance of having the kids in the school. Anyway, I know it's past four. Dr. Wilson, sorry to take you over the time limit. But I did want to say thank you and you know this board is committed to and I hope we'll be continue to be committed to the ongoing process of reviewing our work to make sure it's doing in the field what we intended it to do when we put it out there and your participation and your willingness to talk to us about that is an essential part of that process. So once again

[02:13:24] thank you so much. And so with that what President Gecker said thank you all so much. So I will ask and i i hope you all will agree that as we continue this work that we can look back to you all individually and as a group for your feedback your guidance your insights your perspectives so that we are making appropriate steps forward to where it is we all want our schools and our children to be so thank you all for that if there's nothing else from the committee

[02:13:59] i will adjourn the meeting at 4 4 pm we'll see board members tomorrow morning for our regular business meeting thank you all again have a great afternoon thanks everybody thank you

